prompt elimination of the offensive weapons now in Cuba.'[34] A blockade would lead to negotiations, which he strongly opposed. A blockade could be accepted, though, as the first step in an attack should the demand to remove the missiles be refused. Dillon was prepared to issue an ultimatum to the Cubans (rather than the Soviets), but if this were rejected, an air strike should follow no later than seventy-two hours after the public declaration. If that approach was 'not militarily acceptable or if such delay would involve inacceptable [sic] risks of the use of nuclear weapons against the US, I would favor an early strike in accordance with the air strike course of action.'[35] Dillon's assessment implies that Soviet preparations to make the missiles operational indicated willingness to launch them. In short, a US attack would be pre-emptive in nature.

Tempers of the moment

On Wednesday morning, 17 October, Adlai Stevenson penned an 'eyes only' letter to the President. The ambassador warned of likely Soviet reprisals to military action, including against Turkey or Berlin, and emphasised the need to 'have as much of the world with us as possible'. 'To start or risk starting a nuclear war,' he wrote with remarkable understatement, 'is bound to be divisive at best.' Moreover, he contended, the 'judgments of history seldom coincide with the tempers of the moment'.[36]

Stevenson alluded to Kennedy's 'dilemma' in wanting to strike before the missiles were operational and accepted that, 'The national security must come first.' If 'the Soviets won't remove the missiles and restore the *status quo ante* we will have to do it ourselves.' So, Stevenson made clear his acceptance of using force should diplomacy fail. Nevertheless, he warned Kennedy: 'the means adopted [air strikes] have such incalculable consequences that I feel you should have made it clear that the existence of nuclear bases anywhere is negotiable before we start anything.'[37] He concluded: 'blackmail and intimidation *never,*negotiation and sanity *always.'*